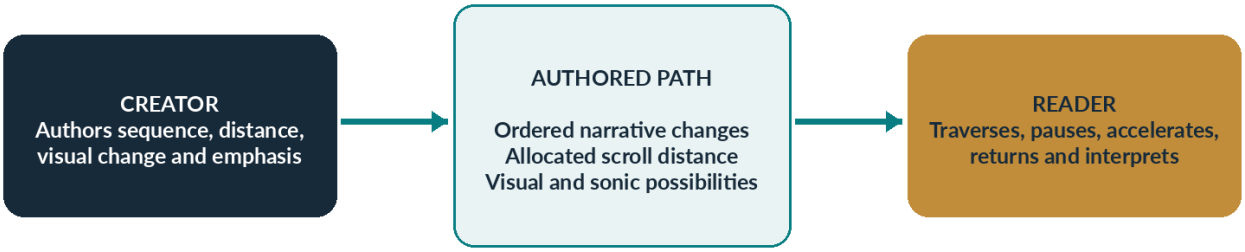
SCROL-A-VISION

SCROLL-DRIVEN STORYTELLING GRAMMAR

DOCUMENT A / THE CREATIVE STANDARD

A philosophy and compositional language for stories in which **the reader's movement becomes part of the work's rhythm**.



EXPERIENCE = authored composition + reader-controlled duration
The creator composes the path; the reader conducts the encounter.

VERSION 1.2 • FOUNDATIONAL CREATIVE STANDARD

October 2026

Compose the path. Shape the interval. Let the reader conduct the encounter.

> **Edition note**
>
> This proposed v1.2 develops the philosophy and terminology of the supplied v1.1 document into a more cohesive creative standard. It draws comparisons with existing art forms while treating scroll-driven storytelling as a developing practice, not as a claim that scrolling alone is historically unprecedented.

How to use this standard

This document defines the creative principles and shared vocabulary of scroll-driven storytelling. It is intended for writers, visual artists, directors, animators, sound designers, interaction designers and engineers who need to collaborate without reducing the work to a list of effects.

Its governing idea is simple: **the creator composes a path of meaningful changes; the reader determines the pace at which that path is encountered.** The standard explains what this means artistically, how it relates to other media, and how to use a common grammar without prescribing one style of story.

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> **How to read requirement words**
>
> In this creative standard, **MUST** identifies a condition necessary to preserve a term's defined meaning or to make the production record intelligible; **SHOULD** names the recommended practice, with justified artistic exceptions; **MAY** identifies an optional approach. These words do not turn aesthetic quality into an automated pass/fail test.

1. Purpose and scope

A shared artistic language, not a recipe for a single style.

Scroll-Driven Storytelling Grammar defines how a story may be composed when the reader's movement through a continuous digital path is one of the means by which the work unfolds. It gives creative teams a vocabulary for narrative change, spatial pacing, visual attention, rhythm, pause, sound, recurrence and transition.

The standard is concerned first with **artistic intention**: what changes, why it matters, how it is approached, and what relation one moment bears to another. It is not a software schema, a list of animation presets, or a rule that every work must contain music, camera motion, dialogue, branching choices or every level of the hierarchy.

The grammar is both descriptive and generative. It describes recognisable features of the form; it also gives creators a way to invent new works, communicate decisions across disciplines and evaluate whether each compositional choice serves the work.

> **Scope statement**
>
> A work belongs to this practice when the reader's traversal of an authored scroll path is deliberately used as a compositional material. A page that merely happens to be tall, or an animation that happens to start on scroll, does not by itself realise the grammar.

2. Defining scroll-driven storytelling

The defining property is not scrolling alone, but authored traversal.

Scroll-driven storytelling is a digital narrative form in which a reader's movement along an authored path governs the progression through a composition of narrative changes and visual states, while the spatial arrangement of those changes contributes to meaning. The work may combine illustration, sequential images, text, animation, camera-like movement, sound and silence. These are available materials, not mandatory ingredients.

The creator arranges what can be encountered and how its parts relate. The reader's scroll gesture determines how quickly the path is traversed, whether the reader lingers, and whether the experience is revisited or reversed. Meaning emerges from the relationship between the authored composition and this reader-controlled encounter.

This definition places the form between fixed-duration presentation and freely navigated narrative. It can borrow from both, but its default contract is distinctive: **the authored sequence is composed spatially; its duration is performed by the reader.** The reader controls traversal pace without necessarily controlling plot outcomes.

The form need not be purely linear, exclusively vertical, silent, static or illustration-only. Such choices depend on the work. A directed path is the simplest baseline; alternatives and branches may be added when they are intentionally authored. Vertical scrolling is a common implementation, but the central principle is movement along a continuous, ordered compositional path.

3. What other art forms contribute

The grammar is a synthesis, not a claim that its ingredients are new.

No art form develops in isolation. Scroll-driven storytelling learns from existing forms by translating their principles into a different relation between space, sequence and reader action. These comparisons identify sources of inspiration, not rigid boundaries between media.

Art form	What it contributes	What scroll-driven storytelling changes
Comics and manga	Framing, sequence, juxtaposition, visual emphasis, and the interpretive work done between images. McCloud's account of comics foregrounds closure, time and motion as part of the reader's activity [1].	The gap is not limited to the space between fixed panels or pages. Distance along the path can be deliberately expanded, compressed or animated, making traversal itself part of the composition.
Music	Phrasing, rhythm, motif, dynamics, tension, release and the expressive role of silence. Musical phrasing gives direction and relation to a sequence rather than treating every note as equally emphatic [2].	Scroll distance and visual change can function as pacing materials, but they are not literally musical notes or beats. The analogy guides composition; it does not require one-to-one mapping to bars, metres or tempo markings.
Cinema	Framing, camera movement, editing, sound, juxtaposition and the construction of time through shot duration and transitions [3].	A film generally presents an authored duration; a scroll-driven work allocates a spatial traversal that the reader moves through at a self-chosen rate. The reader can pause or reverse without that action being a failure of playback.
Literature	Narrative voice, implication, motif, rhythm in language, withheld information and reader interpretation.	Language may coexist with changing visual states. The reader does not only imagine a scene from prose; they physically traverse a composition in which visual disclosure is arranged along a path.
Dance and performance	Time shaped through movement, space, phrasing, energy and transitions [4].	The reader's gesture does not become a literal performance of the character's action. It becomes the means of conducting the encounter: moving, stopping, returning and accelerating through the authored work.
Hypertext and games	Reader choice, nonlinearity, participation and possible variation in narrative path. Hypertext commonly organises material as linked nodes and multiple pathways [5].	Traversal agency must be distinguished from plot agency. Scrolling changes the pace of encounter; a choice changes the narrative path or world only when the work explicitly gives it that power.
Vertical-scroll comics and web works	A close neighbouring practice in which a continuous scroll supports pacing, reveals and extended visual space. Vertical-scroll webcomics are an established digital form, not an invention claimed by this document [6].	This grammar articulates a broader production language for narrative hierarchy, continuous state change, authored distance, camera-like composition, sound and cross-disciplinary direction. It does not claim ownership of vertical scrolling or invalidate other practices.

The newness, where it exists, lies not in any single ingredient. It lies in the deliberate integration of **spatially authored narrative distance, reader-controlled traversal, visual-state composition and an explicit grammar for directing the relationship among them**. Whether a particular work achieves this is a compositional question, not a declaration that a new medium has been conclusively established by terminology alone.

4. The core principles

These principles guide the creative use of every other term.

1. Traversal is part of the work.

The reader's movement is not merely a way to reach content. The composition may use the movement, distance and possibility of return to shape attention and expectation.

2. Distance must have a purpose.

Distance may create anticipation, contemplation, separation, impact, transition or contrast. Long distance is not inherently slow or meaningful; its effect depends on what changes across it.

3. The author composes possibility; the reader performs duration.

The author designs the path and its potential pacing. The reader determines the actual rate of traversal. An author may encourage lingering, but cannot assume that a given scroll distance equals a fixed number of seconds.

4. Every Beat has a discernible contribution.

A Beat introduces, changes, reveals, emphasizes, resolves or interrupts something. Not every Beat must be dramatic, but its primary reason for existing should be explainable.

5. Absence is a compositional choice.

Empty space, quiet, stillness, withholding and delayed disclosure can carry meaning. They should be distinguished from accidental gaps, missing assets or unconsidered dead space.

6. Continuity and discontinuity are both available.

A work may flow through a continuous transformation or create an abrupt cut. Neither is inherently superior. The chosen relationship should serve the passage and the experience.

7. The visual and sonic layers can agree or counterpoint.

Sound may reinforce the image, anticipate it, contradict it, continue across a visual change or fall away. It should have an authored relationship to the narrative rather than exist as automatic decoration.

8. Structure serves experience.

The hierarchy helps creators reason about a work. It need not appear as visible menus, numbered units or conventional chapters to the reader.

9. Traversal agency is not automatically plot agency.

A reader may control pace, pause and return while encountering a fixed sequence. Branching and consequential choice are optional extensions and must be clearly designed when used.

10. The grammar guides judgment; it does not replace it.

Software can check completeness and consistency. It cannot reliably prove that a reveal is moving, a silence is affecting, or a phrase expresses one coherent idea.

5. The model of the work

A work has an authored structure, a path of traversal and an encountered experience.

A useful way to reason about a scroll-driven work is to distinguish three related layers:

Layer	Question it answers	What belongs here
Narrative structure	What is changing, and why does it matter?	Story, Movement, Passage, Phrase, Beat; purpose; narrative function; conditions before and after a change.

Layer	Question it answers	What belongs here
Compositional path	How is the change encountered?	Order, distance, spacing, pauses, transitions, visual disclosure, camera-like movement and placement of text or sound.
Encountered state	What does the reader perceive at this position?	The visible composition, legible text, audible material, level of motion, and current relation among layers.

These layers inform one another but are not interchangeable. A narrative state is not the same as a camera position. A camera movement is not the same as a narrative reveal. A visual pause is not automatically an audio silence. Keeping the concepts distinct lets creators combine them without confusing what the work means with how it is presented.

The word *score* can be a useful metaphor for the authored path: it describes a structured set of relationships that can be encountered at variable rates. It should not be taken to mean a musical score, a fixed timing sheet or a technical playback format.

6. The canonical narrative hierarchy

The hierarchy describes composition from the complete work to its smallest intentional narrative change.

Unit	Definition	Guiding question
Story	The complete work and its overall field of meaning.	What experience or transformation does the work hold together?
Movement	A major dramatic progression that changes or deliberately reframes the condition of the story.	What is different, newly possible, newly understood or intentionally left unresolved by its end?
Passage	A continuous compositional section organised around one dominant narrative purpose.	What single experience or progression holds this section together?
Phrase	A group of at least two Beats that expresses one recognisable narrative idea, action or turn.	What does this group of changes mean as a unit?
Beat	The smallest intentional narrative change in the authored sequence.	What becomes present, different, known, important, interrupted or resolved here?

This hierarchy is conceptual, not a requirement that the reader see five nested containers. Each unit belongs to one parent in the canonical structure. A work may remain unfinished while being authored; a published work should not contain empty structural units that have been presented as complete. Specific structural constraints should be documented in the production specification, not improvised differently by each tool.

> **Important distinction: Beat is not a musical beat**
>
> A narrative **Beat** is an intentional unit of change. A musical beat is a pulse or metrical unit. They may align in a particular work, but they are not equivalent. A narrative Beat may span many musical pulses, occur between pulses or have no music at all.

7. Beat

The smallest intentional narrative change.

A Beat makes something present, different, known, important, interrupted or resolved. It may alter action, knowledge, perception, emotion, space, time or the reader's relation to a subject. A Beat is defined by its narrative contribution, not by its visual size, duration, animation complexity or position on the screen.

A Beat may be rendered through a single static image, a change of framing, a long approach, a text fragment, a sound cue, a sequence of transformations or a deliberate reduction of information. One Beat may affect multiple channels; a complex visual event is not automatically several Beats unless it contains distinct narrative changes.

Primary Beat functions

Function	Definition	Typical question
INTRODUCE	Brings a subject, condition, object, question or possibility into narrative attention.	What enters the work's field of attention?
CHANGE	Alters a condition, action, relationship, perception or expectation already established.	What is different now?
REVEAL	Makes information available that was previously hidden, withheld or not understood.	What can now be perceived or understood?
EMPHASIZE	Increases the prominence, weight or salience of something already present, without requiring new information.	What should the reader notice or feel as important?
RESOLVE	Settles, answers or meaningfully transforms a question, tension or action within its stated scope.	What is now settled, concluded or redefined?
INTERRUPT	Breaks an established continuity, pattern or expectation so that the break itself contributes meaning.	What expected flow is broken, and why?

Every Beat SHOULD have one primary function selected according to its main contribution. Other effects may be recorded as secondary notes. The functions are a common vocabulary, not a claim that every artistic event fits neatly into only one interpretation.

A Beat SHOULD be described in a sentence that states both the change and its narrative relevance. "The camera zooms in" describes a technique. "The reader discovers the mark on the object that identifies who left it" states a narrative change; zooming in may be one way to produce it.

8. Phrase

A meaningful unit built from Beats.

A Phrase contains at least two Beats and expresses one recognisable idea, action, observation or turn. The Phrase is the level at which individual changes acquire a larger shape. It can establish a pattern, develop an action, create a comparison, move from uncertainty to knowledge or set up an expectation that remains unresolved.

A Phrase has a discernible beginning and an intelligible relation among its Beats. It does not need a tidy conclusion. A Phrase may end on a suspension or question when that unresolved condition is deliberately carried forward. The defining test is not whether the Phrase feels complete in isolation, but whether its Beats form a meaningful unit.

Phrase is borrowed from music as a principle of directed grouping, not as a requirement for fixed bar lengths, regular metre or balanced antecedent-and-consequent structures. Phrases may be uneven, interrupted, repeated, fragmented or extended when the work calls for it.

9. Passage

The main directing unit.

A Passage joins Phrases into a continuous experience governed by one dominant narrative purpose. It is the principal level at which the creator considers the allocation of scroll distance, the relation between visual states, the development of tension, and the experience of entry and exit.

A Passage SHOULD leave the reader in a condition that differs from its entry, even if the change is subtle: knowledge may have increased, attention may have shifted, a question may have become more urgent, or a relationship may have been reframed. If it deliberately preserves the same condition, that preservation must itself have a purpose, such as anticipation or contemplation.

Optional structural roles within a Passage

Role	Meaning
Entry	Establishes the condition, question, or visual field from which the Passage begins.
Development	Changes, complicates, tests or deepens that condition.
Dominant	A point of greatest local emphasis within the Passage, when such a point is intended.
Exit	Leaves the reader in the resulting condition or carries an unresolved condition forward.

These are roles, not mandatory steps or additional hierarchy levels. A short Passage may move directly from Entry to Exit. The Dominant may coincide with a Reveal, a Climax, a visual Splash or an audio peak, but none of these terms means the same thing.

10. Movement and Story

Large-scale change is measured in dramatic condition, not geography alone.

A Movement is a major progression composed of Passages. Its defining question is: what is different by the end? The difference may concern a relationship, a conflict, the meaning of an object, the nature of a mystery, a character's commitment or the reader's understanding of the world. A location change by itself does not necessarily create a new Movement.

A Movement may deliberately defer a larger resolution. In that case, the deferral SHOULD alter or sharpen something meaningful: the question becomes more specific, the stakes rise, a new contradiction appears, or a possibility is removed. Merely withholding change without changing the experience does not by itself establish a dramatic progression.

A Story is the complete work. Its unity may arise from plot, theme, character, motif, a journey of perception, or another organising principle. A Story need not follow a conventional three-act structure. The grammar provides a way to compose and discuss relationships; it does not prescribe a universal plot formula.

11. Moment and state

A Moment is an encountered state, not another level in the hierarchy.

A **Moment** is the observable state of the composition at a particular position along the authored path. It may be static, subtly animated, in transition, sparse or visually dense. The Moment is what the reader encounters at a given point; it need not correspond to a separate authored unit.

For clear collaboration, distinguish three meanings of state:

- **Narrative condition:** what is true in the story, what a character knows, or what has changed in the fictional situation.
- **Presentation condition:** what the work currently shows or sounds, including framing, visible elements, text, motion and audio.
- **Encountered Moment:** the resulting perceivable composition at a particular position in the path.

A Beat usually changes narrative condition or the reader's access to it. The creator chooses a presentation strategy. The player resolves that strategy into an encountered Moment. One Beat may produce many intermediate Moments; one Moment may reflect several layers acting together.

12. Scroll, distance and duration

The path is space that the reader traverses; its distance is not literal time.

Scroll position represents progress along the authored composition. Authored scroll distance is the physical or navigational interval allocated between narrative changes. The reader's scroll speed is the rate at which they traverse that interval. These are separate variables and MUST NOT be treated as interchangeable.

Term	Definition	Creative consequence
Narrative position	Where the reader is in the authored sequence.	Determines which part of the story is being encountered.
Scroll position	The current location along the experience's scroll path.	Provides a controllable coordinate for progression.
Authored distance	The interval allotted to a change or sequence.	Shapes anticipation, separation, immediacy, contemplation or impact.
Traversal speed	How quickly the reader moves through the path.	Determines actual encounter rate; it remains under reader control unless an explicit mode changes it.
Duration	The real elapsed time spent encountering a part of the work.	Can vary from reader to reader and from one reading to another.

The relationship between distance and change is expressive but contextual. A large distance with little visible change may create anticipation, travel, contemplation or silence. A small distance with a large change may create impact, interruption or sudden recognition. A large distance with a large change may create an extended transformation. These are compositional possibilities, not fixed laws.

A useful design question is: **what does the distance ask the reader to do or expect?** If the answer is "nothing," the distance may be accidental. If the answer is "wait for a revelation," "feel the separation," "notice the accumulation," or "move gradually into a new perspective," the distance has a stated purpose.

The author can encourage a pause or a slower encounter, but cannot assume that a scroll interval guarantees a fixed real-time duration. Any timed hold or automatic playback mode is an additional authored behaviour and should be identified as such.

13. Tempo and rhythm

Tempo is the perceived rate of meaningful change, not the reader's measured scrolling speed.

Tempo describes how densely meaningful changes are encountered across a passage of traversal. It emerges from the relationship among authored distance, Beat density, the magnitude of changes, the complexity of what must be read or perceived, and the way those changes are spaced.

The terms SLOW, MODERATE and FAST are relative production labels for intended pacing. They are not universal numeric values and should not be automatically inferred from scroll speed. What feels slow in a sequence of spare images may feel fast in a passage of dense text or rapidly changing detail.

Rhythm is the pattern of relations among changes: repetition, spacing, accent, interval, recurrence, suspension and variation. It can be regular or irregular, predictable or disrupted. A work may establish a rhythm and then interrupt it; the deviation derives meaning from the pattern the reader has already encountered.

The creator SHOULD consider at least three distinct densities: the density of narrative changes, the density of visual or sonic information, and the physical distance over which the reader encounters them. They can reinforce one another or work in counterpoint. No single density should be treated as a substitute for the others.

14. Pause, silence, void and gutter

Absence is meaningful when it has a compositional function.

Term	Definition	What it does not automatically mean
Pause	An intentional interval in which narrative change is absent or minimal. The presentation may remain active or still.	It does not require literal stillness, a timed wait or silence in every channel.
Silence	An intentional absence or reduction of audible material, including music, ambience, voice or sound effects.	It does not require the visual composition to become empty or motionless.
Void	An interval of deliberately reduced visual information.	It does not require audio to stop, and it is not synonymous with a loading gap or missing asset.
Gutter	The implied or explicit separation between visual events through which a reader infers relation, passage or omission.	It is not necessarily empty white space and need not be bounded by a traditional panel.
Rest	A useful music-derived metaphor for a deliberately unfilled interval within an ongoing pattern. Use it descriptively rather than as a separate mandatory structural unit.	It is not automatically the same thing as a Pause, Silence or Void.

These conditions can overlap. A Void may create a Pause. A Silence may occur during intense camera movement. A Pause may contain environmental sound. A Gutter may be narrow or extensive. The work's effect comes from the relationship among what is absent, what remains, and what the reader has been led to expect.

Absence MUST be intentional if it is being used as part of the grammar. Authors and implementers should distinguish a deliberate interval from broken media, delayed loading, inaccessible text or accidental whitespace.

15. Dynamics, emphasis and resolution

Intensity has several dimensions; do not compress them into one presumed scale.

Dynamics describe how perceived intensity develops across a unit or passage. The standard recognises six common shapes:

Shape	Meaning
FLAT	The intended intensity remains relatively level.
ASCENDING	Intensity generally rises across the relevant span.

Shape	Meaning
DESCENDING	Intensity generally falls across the relevant span.
PEAK	Intensity reaches a point of maximum relative emphasis within the span.
VALLEY	Intensity reaches a point of minimum relative emphasis within the span.
OSCILLATING	Intensity rises and falls repeatedly or in a patterned alternation.

These shapes describe the intended contour, not a universal numerical measure. Dramatic intensity, visual intensity and audio intensity may diverge. A scene can grow more emotionally significant while becoming quieter, visually simpler or slower. The creator should identify the relevant channel when that distinction matters.

Related terms

- **Emphasis** is the act of directing attention or increasing the perceived importance of an element. It may be produced by scale, contrast, timing, isolation, repetition, motion, sound or the removal of competing information.
- **Dominant** is a structural role: the point of greatest local emphasis within a Passage, when one is designated.
- **Climax** is the point of greatest dramatic intensity or consequence within a stated scope. A Passage may have a local climax; a whole Story may have a larger one. Not every Passage requires a climax.
- **Peak** describes the shape of an intensity progression. It may coincide with a Climax or Dominant, but it can also describe a purely visual or sonic contour.
- **Resolution** is the condition established when a question, tension or action is settled or meaningfully transformed. It may occur at several scales and need not mean that every mystery or conflict is finished.

A Crescendo is an intentional increase in musical or sonic intensity; by analogy, the term may describe a broader cross-modal build-up only when the author makes clear which dimensions are intensifying. A Decrescendo is a decrease in sonic intensity, or a stated analogy in another channel. These terms should not be used as vague synonyms for “more exciting” and “less exciting.”

16. Visual grammar, camera and transitions

The camera directs attention; a transition describes a relation between states.

Core visual concepts

Concept	Definition
Framing	Defines what is included in the visible field and what is excluded.
Scale	Defines the relative visual size of a subject or element and can influence intimacy, distance or importance.
Composition	The arrangement of visual elements and their relationships within the current field.
Juxtaposition	The placement of images, states or ideas in relation so their proximity or contrast creates meaning.
Splash	A deliberately dominant composition occupying most or all of the reader’s viewing field.
Motivic framing	A repeated framing or compositional relationship that helps an element become recognisable across the work.

The “camera” is the reader’s changing viewpoint within a visual composition. It may be implemented as a literal virtual camera, as a crop or viewport moving over two-dimensional artwork, or as a change in the relative arrangement of layers. The concept is functional rather than tied to one software implementation.

Camera operations

- **Approach:** the viewpoint moves closer to a subject or detail, or the subject grows in the field of view. The intended result may be intimacy, inspection, threat or discovery.
- **Retreat:** the viewpoint moves away or the subject becomes smaller in the field. The intended result may be context, distance, exposure or release.
- **Reframe:** the visible field changes to redirect attention without necessarily changing the story-world position of its elements.
- Additional movements such as lateral travel, vertical travel, pan, tilt, zoom or layered parallax MAY be used when they serve the composition and are described clearly enough for implementation.

Transition relationships

Term	Definition	Category
Continuation	An action, composition or condition proceeds without a categorical break.	Relationship between states
Cut	The visual state changes abruptly, without a gradual blend.	Transition method
Dissolve	One visual state gradually gives way to another, often allowing overlap.	Transition method
Transformation	One visible form or state changes continuously into another.	Transition method
Reveal	Previously hidden, withheld or unnoticed information becomes available.	Narrative information operation
Void	A deliberately reduced visual interval between or within states.	Compositional interval

These terms belong to different conceptual categories and SHOULD NOT be forced into one mutually exclusive list. A Beat may perform a Reveal through an Approach and a Dissolve. A Cut can introduce an interruption, but a Cut is not itself a narrative function. A Void can separate two states or occur within one Passage. The author identifies the narrative effect and the means used to create it.

17. Motif and repetition

Recurrence creates recognition; context creates development.

A Motif is a recurring image, sound, phrase, object, movement, colour relationship, framing pattern or other recognisable element whose recurrence contributes to meaning. It must retain enough identity to be recognised, while its context may change how it is understood.

Repetition is not automatically a Motif. A repeated element becomes motivic when its recurrence is intentionally organised to establish recognition, comparison, expectation or transformation. A Motif may gather meaning, change meaning, become absent when expected, or return in a changed form.

Creators SHOULD document a Motif's identity, its intended significance, and its major occurrences when that knowledge is needed by collaborators. Recognition and significance remain artistic judgments; software can help track occurrences but cannot prove that the Motif succeeds.

18. Text, sound and counterpoint

Words, images and sound share the work's rhythm without becoming the same material.

Dialogue, narration, captions, sound effects and other text are part of the composition. Their position, density, phrasing and order affect how the visual field is read. Text may be a Beat's primary vehicle, but it may also support, contrast with, or remain in tension with an image.

Sound follows the hierarchy of narrative intention even when it does not align one-to-one with individual Beats. It may start before a visual reveal, continue across a Cut, reinforce a repeated Motif, oppose the image's emotional direction, or disappear at a moment of emphasis.

A musical pulse is not required to align with a narrative Beat. A passage may use a regular musical pattern while narrative changes occur at irregular intervals; it may also place visual changes against the expected rhythm. Such counterpoint is intentional when the difference contributes to the experience, not merely when the layers happen to drift apart.

The production record SHOULD clarify where text and sound enter, persist, change or end, and how they behave when a reader pauses, reverses or revisits the path. The specific playback rules belong in the technical specification; the artistic intent belongs here.

19. Reader agency and paths

Control over pace is not the same as control over the story's outcome.

The default reader relationship in scroll-driven storytelling is **traversal agency**: the reader chooses when to move, how quickly to move, when to pause, and whether to revisit prior material. This gives the reader control over duration of encounter without necessarily changing the authored sequence or narrative world.

A work MAY provide additional forms of agency. These should be distinguished rather than described generically as "interactive."

Path model	Description	Creative implication
Directed path	A principal ordered route through the work.	The author shapes sequence; the reader controls traversal pace and return.
Optional detour	A supplementary route or layer that can be explored without changing the core sequence.	The reader controls depth of exploration; the work should make the relation to the main path intelligible.
Branching path	A choice selects between authored continuations or changes the narrative state.	The reader exercises path or plot agency beyond pacing; consequences and return behaviour should be designed explicitly.
Layered path	Multiple visual, textual or sonic strands can be encountered in different relations while retaining a designed composition.	The work may support comparison, discovery and variable attention; the relationship among layers must remain intentional.

A path may be revisited in reverse. By default, the same position in the authored path SHOULD resolve to the same intended presentation state, because this allows readers to inspect, pause and retrace the work. One-shot effects, external state changes and deliberate irreversible behaviours are exceptions that require explicit design. The creative standard establishes the expectation; the playback specification must define the precise behaviour.

20. A compositional practice

The grammar is most useful when applied as a sequence of creative decisions.

The following practice is a guide rather than a mandatory production pipeline. Creators may move back and forth among stages as the work develops.

1. Name the intended change.

Describe what becomes different, newly known, newly important or newly unresolved. Begin with meaning rather than an effect.

2. Group the change.

Place the Beat inside a Phrase, Passage and Movement where appropriate. Ask what the group contributes that an isolated Beat would not.

3. Choose the perceptual vehicle.

Decide whether the change is carried by image, text, sound, motion, framing, juxtaposition, withheld information or a combination.

4. Compose the interval.

Decide how much traversal the change needs and what the distance should make possible: anticipation, observation, impact, reflection, progression or contrast.

5. Shape the relation.

Select camera operations, transitions, dynamics and Motif relations. Distinguish what changes in the story from how it is presented.

6. Test the reader's encounter.

Read the work at different scroll speeds. Pause and reverse. Check whether the important relation survives a quick traversal and whether the intended delay earns its distance.

7. Record what collaborators need.

Document narrative purpose, required state changes, relevant assets, text and sound behaviour, and any exception to the expected traversal model.

8. Revise by effect, not ornament.

Keep an effect because it contributes to meaning, attention, rhythm or atmosphere. Remove or alter it when it obscures the primary change.

21. Creative commitments and review

The grammar should support judgment, not automate taste.

The following commitments express the standard's intended discipline. They guide authors and collaborators and can also inform editorial review.

- Every Beat has one identifiable primary narrative function, even when it has other effects.
- Every Phrase groups at least two Beats around a recognisable idea, action or turn.
- Every Passage has one dominant narrative purpose and leaves the reader in an intelligible resulting condition, including a deliberately unresolved one.
- Every Movement changes or deliberately reframes the dramatic condition of the Story.
- Scroll distance has an intentional relationship to pacing, attention, separation, anticipation, impact or transition.
- Pauses, Silences, Voids and Gutters are deliberate compositional decisions, not substitutes for missing content.
- Transition methods and narrative functions are recorded as different kinds of decision.
- Motifs are repeated with enough identity to be recognised and enough contextual variation to matter, when motivic development is intended.
- Text and sound have an intentional relation to the visual composition, including when they deliberately contrast.
- The path can be encountered at different speeds without relying on a single assumed real-time duration.

- Exceptions to normal reverse traversal or state reconstruction are deliberate and documented.
- Technical implementation serves the author's declared intention and does not silently redefine the grammar.

Editorial questions

- Can the primary function of each Beat be stated clearly?
- Does each Phrase contain a coherent relation among its Beats?
- Does the Passage have a dominant purpose, and can its entry and exit conditions be described?
- What meaning is created by the spacing between changes?
- Does the experience still communicate at both a quick and a deliberate traversal pace?
- Are silence, absence, repetition and transition intentional?
- Do visual and sonic layers reinforce or counterpoint one another for a reason?
- Can another collaborator understand the creative intention without having to invent missing narrative logic?
- Which parts require human editorial judgment rather than a mechanical validation rule?

22. Worked example: Discovery

One Passage demonstrates the relationship between narrative change and compositional distance.

Passage P03 — Discovery
Purpose: A character discovers an object whose significance is not initially understood.

Unit	Narrative intent	Possible composition
Entry	The character enters an abandoned room.	Establish the room's scale and spatial orientation. Keep the object unremarkable or outside the visible field.
Phrase 1: Observation	The room is observed.	Allocate enough distance for details to be noticed. A slow lateral or vertical traversal may establish texture and emptiness.
Phrase 2: Attraction	A sound draws the character toward a corner.	Introduce sound before fully disclosing its source. Use spacing to build expectation; do not assume every reader will wait the same duration.
Phrase 3: Reveal	The object becomes visible.	Use an Approach, a Cut, a Dissolve or another appropriate method. Reveal names the information change; the transition method describes how it happens.
Dominant	The object fills the visual field.	A Splash or close framing may create emphasis. This is a local structural role and may or may not be the Story's Climax.
Exit	The character recognises the object.	The resulting condition is not only "the object is visible"; the object's meaning has changed for the character and reader.

Intended pacing: SLOW into MODERATE. Intended dynamic: ASCENDING toward a local PEAK, followed by a reduction or reorientation. These labels describe a relative contour; they are not numerical playback instructions. Sound may lead the visual reveal or fall silent at the instant the object becomes visible. That relation is an artistic choice to be documented.

> **What this example demonstrates**
>
> The Beat function, camera operation, transition method, scroll distance and dynamic shape are separate but coordinated decisions. The grammar does not dictate one correct effect. It makes the creator's intention explicit enough that different implementations can be compared against it.

23. Scope of this standard

The creative grammar and the software specification are related, but not identical.

This document defines the creative meanings and compositional principles of the form. It does not define a JSON schema, database model, API, asset package format, exact interpolation algorithm, screen-resizing algorithm, audio event lifecycle or error-handling protocol. Those belong in a companion Story Format and Playback Specification.

The companion specification SHOULD preserve distinctions established here: narrative function is not transition technique; Beat is not a musical pulse; authored distance is not elapsed time; Moment is not a hierarchy level; traversal agency is not automatically plot agency; and editorial judgments are not the same as machine-checkable constraints.

Future revisions of this grammar may add vocabulary or refine definitions. New terms should be introduced only when they describe a meaningful distinction creators need to make. The standard should remain extensible, but not allow identical ideas to accumulate conflicting names. Changes to definitions should be recorded so existing works and collaborators can understand which meaning was intended.

The grammar is not a universal theory of every scrollable artwork. It is a shared standard for one coherent creative practice. It should be tested through actual works, critique and production, and revised where experience reveals ambiguity or unnecessary rigidity.

24. Glossary and references

A compact reference for consistent use of the central terms.

Term	Working definition
Authored path	The ordered compositional route through which narrative changes are encountered.
Beat	The smallest intentional narrative change; not the same as a musical pulse.
Climax	The point of greatest dramatic intensity or consequence within a stated scope.
Dominant	The point of greatest local emphasis within a Passage, when assigned.
Dynamics	The intended contour of perceived intensity across a relevant span.
Gutter	A separation between visual events that invites the reader to infer relation, passage or omission.
Moment	The observable state of the composition at a particular path position.
Motif	A recognisable recurring element whose recurrence contributes meaning.
Passage	A continuous section organised around one dominant narrative purpose.
Pause	An intentional interval of little or no narrative change.
Phrase	At least two Beats grouped around one recognisable narrative idea, action or turn.
Reader traversal	The reader's movement through the authored path, including pace, pausing and return.
Resolution	A condition in which a question, tension or action is settled or meaningfully transformed.
Silence	An intentional absence or reduction of audible material.
Story	The complete work.
Tempo	The perceived rate and density of meaningful change, relative to the passage and work.
Void	An interval of deliberately reduced visual information.
Movement	A major dramatic progression that changes or deliberately reframes the Story's condition.

References and points of comparison

The references below inform the comparison with related art forms. They do not establish that scroll-driven storytelling is unprecedented; the framework's proposed synthesis and definitions are the creative position of this standard.

[1] Scott McCloud. *Understanding Comics: The Invisible Art.* HarperPerennial, 1993. Author's overview identifies closure, reader participation between panels, word-picture relations, time and motion as central topics.

https://www.scottmccloud.com/2-print/1-uc/index.html

[2] Michel Debost. *The Simple Flute: From A to Z*, chapter "Phrasing." Oxford University Press, 2002. Discusses phrasing as direction and relation among tension, release, intensity, repose, time and silence.

https://academic.oup.com/book/50104/chapter-abstract/422362958

[3] "Editing." *I've Seen Things: A Survey of Film.* Pressbooks. Educational overview of editing as the construction of meaningful sequences, time, space, pace and rhythm.

https://icc.pressbooks.pub/iccfilm110/chapter/chapter-6-editing/

[4] "The Philosophy of Dance." *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, Spring 2019 archive. Discusses dance in relation to music and theatre, including rhythm, temporality, movement through space and expressive gesture.

https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/spr2019/entries/dance/

[5] Astrid Ensslin. "Hypertext Theory." *Oxford Research Encyclopedia of Literature*, published 31 March 2020. Describes hypertext through nodes, links, networks, reader choices and multilinear pathways.

https://academic.oup.com/edited-volume/61883/chapter-abstract/547774174

[6] WEBTOON Entertainment. "Webcomics Are Winning Over the Gen Z Scroll." 21 September 2026. A current platform description of vertical-scroll webcomics as a mobile-native storytelling format; cited only to acknowledge this established neighbouring practice.

https://ir.webtoon.com/news-releases/news-release-details/webcomics-are-winning-over-gen-z-scroll

The standard in one sentence

Scroll-driven storytelling is the art of composing meaningful change along a path whose distance shapes expectation and whose duration is conducted by the reader.